

Apurva Bhatnagar, PhD

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Profile

I am a development economist with eight years of experience working on health, nutrition, and social development programs in India and across South Asia, Southeast Asia, and Africa. Most of my work has been in direct partnership with government stakeholders, leaders and changemakers. I help them understand how programs are performing and where to focus their resources. I have substantive experience in designing quantitative analysis and narrative building, making the case for what the data shows. My research has directly shaped government guidelines in Delhi, informed budget priorities in Uttar Pradesh and influenced program design across the Philippines and Cambodia.

Skills

Research and Evaluation: Randomised controlled trials, process evaluations, survey design and management at national scale, sampling (including voter-roll and GPS pin-drop), power calculations, results frameworks, mixed-methods research.

India Expertise: Direct advisory partnerships with central and state governments on health, nutrition, and social programs; Indian administrative data systems; public finance analysis.

Data Analysis: Expert proficiency in Stata and R; reproducible data pipelines, indicator construction, and data visualisation for non-technical audiences.

Project Management: End-to-end management of complex multi-country projects; senior government and NGO partner engagement; team mentoring and capacity building.

Experience

- IDinsight** **2021 – Present**
Development Economist / Technical Manager *India and Global*

Selected Projects:

IFS India Impact Measurement Initiative – Bill & Melinda Gates Foundation **2024 – Present**
Project Manager *India*

- Manage a pan-India financial inclusion measurement initiative for the Gates Foundation end to end: funder relationship and reporting, budget, field operations, technical design, and final analysis and dissemination.
- Delivered a nationally representative baseline survey across 23 states and union territories and 9,743 households (more than 250 indicators on bank accounts, digital payments, savings, credit, insurance, pensions, and women's economic empowerment), using voter-roll and GPS pin-drop sampling deployed at national scale for the first time.

State Scheme and Budget Review – Government of Uttar Pradesh **2024 – 2025**
Analytical Lead and Reviewer *Uttar Pradesh, India*

- Assess how well state schemes reach their intended beneficiaries and whether budget allocations align with the state's one trillion dollar economy target, triangulating departmental administrative data, the state's Family ID database, rapid phone surveys, and targeted field visits.
- Sole reviewer of all analysis produced by associates on the engagement: I guide and supervise their work and ensure that everything we deliver is methodologically robust and complete.

Early Warning System for School Dropouts – British Asian Trust and DCPCR **2023 – 2024**

Lead, Algorithm Design

New Delhi, India

- Strengthened Delhi's Early Warning System, which tracks daily attendance for roughly 1.8 million students across more than 1,000 government schools to flag children at risk of dropping out and trigger timely support.
- Led and supervised associates to build the dropout-risk prediction algorithm, trained and tested on around 224 million attendance records, replacing arbitrary detection criteria with a calibrated risk score so that scarce intervention resources reach the children who need them most.

Anemia Mukht Bharat – Delhi Commission for Protection of Child Rights **2021 – 2023**

Technical Lead, Process Evaluation

New Delhi, India

- Diagnosed why the state's iron and folic acid supplementation program reached nearly all students in some schools and fewer than half in others despite steady state-level supply; surveyed 900 students across 26 schools and interviewed officials, principals, and teachers, tracing the gap to the absence of any standardised school-level procedure.
- Recommendations were adopted as state guidelines by Delhi's Directorate of Education in March 2023, now covering 1.6 million students.

Health Promotion and Literacy Study – Philippine Dept. of Health **2023 – Present**

Lead, Analysis and Data Quality

Philippines

- Own the data-quality systems, the data-cleaning, analysis and visualisation pipelines, and report writing for a five-year nationally representative panel study with the Philippine Department of Health spanning all 17 regions and the Department's seven health-priority pillars, and review all technical work produced by associates.
- Led a dedicated study on mental health literacy, building a vignette-based measurement tool and combining a nationally representative survey with 50 in-depth interviews; findings fed into national mental health policy.

StrongMinds Uganda – Impact Evaluation of Mental Health Intervention **2026 – Present**

Technical Lead, RCT Design

Uganda

- Provide technical assistance on the design of a village-level cluster randomised controlled trial of StrongMinds' group interpersonal psychotherapy program for depression: the pre-analysis plan, randomisation, power calculations, and outcome measurement.
- Own the survey instrument design, the survey protocol, and the IRB ethics submission, and developed the study's theory of change and the key assumptions to test.

Health and Nutritional Programs Evaluation – CHAI and Nutrition International **2023 – 2025**

Lead, Evaluation Design

India

- Designing a randomised evaluation with the Clinton Health Access Initiative of a community-based household contact management model, led by frontline health workers (ASHAs, TB Health Visitors, and support-agency staff), to deliver TB preventive treatment in high-burden settings in support of India's TB elimination goals.
- Ran the baseline evaluation of Nutrition International's rice-fortification technical assistance in Madhya Pradesh and West Bengal (458 laboratory-tested samples, 218 surveys, 98 interviews); designed the pre-analysis plans and instruments, and findings of more than 97% compliance informed the funder's investment decision.

Portfolio Technical Oversight – IDinsight **2025 – Present**

Technical Reviewer, India Portfolio

India and Global

- Provide analytical oversight across IDinsight’s health, nutrition, and agriculture portfolio, reviewing and quality-checking outputs so that findings are credible and framed to be useful for decision-makers.
- Established organisation-wide coding standards in R, authored IDinsight’s institutional guidelines on using AI tools for qualitative research, and mentor associates and managers on evaluation methods and the communication of results.

Research and Information System for Developing

2018 – 2021

- **Countries (RIS)**

Research Assistant

New Delhi, India

- Conducted policy research on trade and health policy; facilitated high-level dialogues between government ministries, industry leaders, and international organisations.
- Led a qualitative field study in Sichuan, China, on market integration policies for the indigenous medicine sector.

- **Afghanistan Employment Research – ILO**

2017 – 2018

Research Assistant to Dr. Anirban Dasgupta, Consultant

- Analysed household survey data on employment trends in post-conflict Afghanistan; co-authored ILO working papers informing reconstruction policy.

Education

- **Ph.D., Economics**

2019 – 2025

- *Jawaharlal Nehru University*

Income mobility and inequality in India

- **M.Phil., Economics**

2017 – 2019

- *Jawaharlal Nehru University*

- **M.A., Development Economics**

2015 – 2017

- *South Asian University*

Select Publications

1. Bhatnagar, A. (2023). Income mobility across castes in India. *Indian Economic Review*, 58(1), 45–72.
2. Dasgupta, A., Anhal, R., & Bhatnagar, A. (2019). Employment Scenario in Afghanistan. *ILO Asia Pacific Working Paper Series*.
3. Jeong, M., Huang, C., Hipol, M., Bhatnagar, A., et al. (2024). Process evaluation of Cambodia’s Early Grade Learning Program. VVOB Education for Development.